



DER YUULSEGE - YULE SEGE

23. YUULING 2017

ROBERT LUSCH SCHREIWER (MIT DENKI ZUM BRIAN WEIS)
REV - D 7

Honoring: Wudan, Holle, Berchta, Sunna, Waahra

Intonation of the Runes

Each rune intoned thrice: Antwatt (Ansuz), Haagel (Hagalaz), Eisich (Isa), (Sunne) Sowilo, Eiwe (Eihwaz)

Die Heiliching - The Hallowing

*Sichel un Hammer, heilicht daer Aldaar un die Schtell
Beschitzt uns mit der Graft vun de Ziewe,
Bei Wudan un Frigg fer der Gemeeschaft zu baue
Bei Ziu un Zisa fer die Gerechdichkeit un der Fruchsfriede zu erhalde
Bei Frey un Freya fer die Wohldaat zu schneide un sammle
Bei Dunner un Siwwa fer es Volk vollzumechtiche.
Bei Fraa Holle un fer es Volk zu erneire,
Bei Waahra, fer uns zu unsere Eed uffzuhalde,
Wie schmittet der Hammer die Sichel,
So die Sichel der Hammer fiedert.
'S iss es Lewesraad, zu saehe un zu schneide
Hammer un Sichel, heilicht daer Aldaar un die Schtell*

Heel!

Heel!

Heel!

Unser Zweck - Our Purpose

*Heit sammle mir uns do, fer der Wudan, die Holle, die Sunna, un die Waahra zu ehre
Today we are gathered together to honor Wudan, Holle, Sunna, and Waahra.
Hail to the gods! Hail to the goddesses!
Hail to the Land Spirits!
Hail to the Community!*

Der Aaruf - The Invocation

Invocations to Wudan, Holle, Berchta, Sunna, and Waahra will be made both in Deutsch and in English.

Es Opfer un Die Eed - The Offering and the Oaths

Losst uns enniche Opfer uff der Aldaar.

Un wann ennichebber hot en Eed zu bschweere, kumm yetz voraa.

If anyone has any offerings, please place them onto the altar.

If anyone has any oaths to take, come forward now.

Die Eednemming - The Oath-Taking

Today we are honored to have Rebecca Meager and April Gindville joining as Associates.

Die Heiliching vun de Opfer un Eed - Hallowing of the Offerings and Oaths

Die Ausdeeling - The Distribution

Der Sege - The Blessing

When pouring the libations, all say (choose either language):

*Vun de Ziewe zu der Erd zu uns
Vun uns zu der Erd zu de Gedder*

*From the gods to the Earth to us
From us to the Earth to the gods*

*'N Gschenk fer 'n Gschenk
Heele!*

*A gift for a gift.
Hail!*

Zum Schluss - In Closing

Zu de Wichde - To the ights

SAMMEL

Topics for Discussion

Yule is a word all of us have heard since childhood. We hear it buried in Christmas carols (“Have yourself a merry little Christmas, make the Yuletide gay”; “Troll the ancient Yuletide carol, Fa la la la la la la la”; etc.). We may have heard references to Yule logs or even burned or eaten their food from time to time. Most of us grew up thinking that Yule was merely a reference to the Christmas season. We knew there was a “Jesus” Christmas, and we knew there was a “Santa” Christmas, and we figured that the two crossed when it came to concepts of love, family, giving, etc. The holly, mistletoe, wreaths, and trees we usually knew were part of the “Santa” Christmas, but we probably did not realize just how old these items were or how deeply the symbols speak to our subconscious mind.

YULE: The Season IS the Reason!

So what is Yule, anyway? The short answer is that Yule is the time that spans from the winter solstice (the day of the year during which we receive the least amount of sunlight) until the Teutonic New Year’s Day, which matches our New Year’s Day. Traditionally, it is cold, possibly snowy, and dark. So why would anyone celebrate this dreary day? For starters, this is rock bottom; starting with Yule, the amount of sunlight begins to grow daily, and we are reminded that the cycle of the year, as well as the cycle of life, continues unabated, even when things look to be their worst. Within that notion are some subtexts, including the strong presence of Fraa Holle during this time. To put these concepts into their proper setting, we need to step back to Allelieweziel, also known as Halloween.

Braucherei (the Pennsylvania German healing and oral history practice) tradition holds that on Allelieweziel, Fraa Holle has completed Her duties within the Earth and emerges, literally or figuratively, and begins, along with Wudan, die Wild Yacht, or the Wild Hunt. The Wild Hunt consists of quite a few of the Teutonic gods and goddesses along with numerous spirits and entities, including many of those who had passed away earlier during the year.

The Wild Hunt continues throughout the dark half of the year, culminating on Walpurgisnacht (April 30/May 1), when Fraa Holle returns to the Earth. The Wild Hunt was re-enacted in Heathen practices in many ways, from Halloween costumes to the Pennsylvania German King Frost to the concept of Belsnickeling to Mummers to the pre-Christian elements that grew into the Fasching and Mardi Gras traditions to perhaps even the April Fool. Walpurgisnacht is still celebrated in Germany and Austria with costumes and the well-known Maypole. All of these observances re-create the Wild Hunt with outrageous costumes, tricks, games, and celebrations – most aimed at keeping away danger. Interestingly, all of the depictions that traditionally take place before Yule (Allelieweziel, King Frost, Krampuslauf, Belsnickeling) are all dark in content and costume, and all of the depictions after Yule (Mumming, Fasching, April Fool) are brighter in content and costume. Walpurgisnacht is a combination of both light and dark, as is Yule.

Urglaawe “days” begin at sunset (for example, “Thursday” actually begins on Wednesday at sunset). The Yule celebration begins with what is called die Muddernacht, or Mother’s Night, on December 20 and runs for twelve nights and twelve days. Yuletide ends on January 1 at sunset.

To most Heathens, Mother’s Night represents the motherly birthing of the new sun (as Yule also functions as the New Year for the Teutons). Urglaawe tradition differs somewhat due to our cultural context. For us, it is more viewed as the “rebirth” portion of the Lewesraad (Cycle of Life), as the sun is figuratively “reborn.”

Much of Yule revolves around fire: candles, Yule logs, wreaths that are burned with or without New Year's resolutions attached to them. Old myths tell us that our ancestors lit these fires in an effort to help to strengthen the sunlight. It is probable that it was more a symbolic act than one that was taken literally, but, either way, the effect and meaning are the same. All this fire represents the hope of -- or the actual victory of -- the sunlight over the darkness. This ties into the conversations we have recently been having about self-improvement and resolutions for the New Year.

As cited above, prior to Yule, depictions of the Wild Hunt are dark in costume and content. This symbolizes the fact that it is the gloomiest time of the physical year. It also, however, serves as a point of recognition that all humans have a shadow side that we each, as individuals, must contend with within ourselves.

For the past few weeks, we have been discussing contending with the shadow side and living consciously and deliberately to bring about positive change or to remove negative burdens from our lives. In Braucherei, and thence also in Urglaawe, the Yuulzeit is intended to be a time of internalization and family strengthening.

Yule's time of introspection is the perfect period to evaluate what elements in our lives are beneficial to us and which are baneful. By the time that New Year comes, we are to be set to take the actions necessary to reduce or eliminate the baneful influences. We make resolutions and take oaths before the gods and goddesses to make the changes necessary. From this time forward, what we learned during Yule is internalized into our heart and spirits.

Thus, today we honor Sunna, who is the Teutonic "Sun goddess." While we do not believe that Sunna is literally the Sun, nor does She emanate from the Sun, we see in Her the brightness, warmth, and life-giving energy that is associated with the Sun. This brightness extends also, figuratively speaking, to casting light onto our shadow sides.

Berchta's feast day is December 31 (Zwelfdi Nacht/Twelfth Night), and, at that time, we are to eat a prescribed meal of herring and gruel.

So what about Santa? With few exceptions, the Pennsylvania Germans are credited for bringing modern "secular" Christmas traditions to the United States, and thence to the entire world. These traditions include Santa Claus, Mrs. Claus, and those who accompany Santa in his sleigh. References to elves are quite clearly straight out of Teutonic lore. Pennsylvania German lore, particularly within Braucher circles, states that Santa is a representation of Allvadder Wudan. Mrs. Claus is none other than Fraa Holle, and those that accompany them in the sleigh help fill out a picture that the story of Santa Claus is a representation of Wild Hunt. Thus, today we invoke Wudan and Holle along with Sunna.

The evergreens (which can represent the Lewesbaam, World Tree, Yggdrasil), holly, and bayberry are chosen for their persistent ability to keep color throughout the coldest part of the year. These elements focus on the continuance of life and potential for life through the dark times.

Other important Yuletide observances are Berchtaslaaf (the Progression of Berchta) and New Year's Day. Berchtaslaaf begins on Twelfth Night (December 31) and is the close of Yule's Wild Hunt depiction. We are commanded to present Her with an offering of herring and gruel (though regional variations allow for any type of fish and oatmeal), and we are to consume a bit of it ourselves. Twelve Day is January 1, or New Year's Day, which is the Feast of Frey. That is the traditional time for the consumption of pork and sauerkraut (both of which are sacred to Frey) to bring about success and prosperity in the New Year. It is after the Feast of Frey that we burn the Yule wreaths to close out the observance.

Daily Focal Points for Yule:

Throughout all 12 Days: Introspection - der Selbschtreiguck

Day 1: Industriousness - die Schaffichheit (20 into 21)
Stewardship - die Verwalting (20 into 21)

Day 2: Curiosity - die Neigierheit (21 into 22)

Day 3: Courage - der Mut (22 into 23)

Day 4: Generosity - der Edelmut (23 into 24)

Day 5: Hospitality - die Uffwaarting (24 into 25)
Honor - die Ehr (24 into 25)

Day 6: Compassion - es Mitleid (25 into 26)

Day 7: Discipline - die Addning (26 into 27)

Day 8: Self-Reliance - es Selbschtzuverdraue (27 into 28)

Day 9: Troth - die Treie (28 into 29)
Truth - die Waahrheit (28 into 29)

Day 10: Steadfastness - die Ausdauer (29 into 30)
Kinship - die Verwandschaft (29 into 30)

Day 11: Self-Improvement - die Selbschtverbessering (30 into 31)

Day 12: Wisdom - die Weisheit (31 into 1)
Spirituality - die Geischtlichkeet (31 into 1)

ASSOCIATE MEMBERSHIP OATH is preceded by hailing the goddess Waahra (known as Var in the Prose Edda).

The Ring is held by all participating members, whether Full or Prospective/Associate. As Distelfink grows, the Schtaab (staff) will be employed to hold the Ring, and all members touch the Schtaab.

The verbiage of the Associate (or Prospective or Probationary) member oath is below. Please note that prospective associates may edit the verbiage to meet their comfort level with oath-taking. The purpose is the recognition of a community relationship and Frith within the Urglaawe context. The intention is not to box anyone into an oath with which they are not comfortable.

Thus, prospective associates are encouraged to read the text below and to make editions based on their level of comfort.

DISTELFINK REP:

Here we stand before our Gods and Goddesses, our community, the wights of the land, and our ancestors to take these oaths. Today we are blessed by the growth of our membership and tribal identity.

MEMBERS:

Here I stand before the Gods and Goddesses, the community, the wights of the land, and my ancestors to take these oaths. We recognize the full members and associates of Distelfink Sippschaft as our brothers and sisters.

PRESENT MEMBERS:

From this time forward, we know [name] as our [brother/sister] with a stake in the progression of our Sippschaft. We vow to consider their opinions as we make decisions regarding the advancement of Urglaawe, and we recognize them as full stakeholders and voters in our organization.

ALL:

I vow to honor the others and to stand by the members of the Sippschaft through difficult times. I vow to speak my mind without fear, recognizing that we hold each other's best interests at heart. We vow to stand up for each other and to avoid pettiness, which may damage our bond and undermine the Sippschaft.

I vow to nudge any other member or associate should I feel that one of them is wrong, recognizing that sometimes some loving guidance can help avert catastrophe.

I vow to keep open the lines of communication so that, should a problem arise, we may resolve it among ourselves without creating unnecessary tension.

I recognize that, since we are all human, we may occasionally inadvertently create an issue with others. I vow to try to view these situations charitably and to try to resolve conflict with the assumption that no malice was intended.

I also vow to consider the others' opinions should they feel I am wrong, recognizing that ultimately I am responsible for myself and for my decisions.

ALL:

We vow to respect the Earth, as Mannheim is our home, and we must leave it in a blessed state for those that follow and for our next life.

ALL:

We vow to honor our ancestors and each other's ancestors, and those individuals who pioneered the way for our freedom of religious expression.

We recognize that these oaths do not limit our freedom of conscience or of thought.

ALL:

We vow to journey together, learning together the secrets of the past and the splendor of the present while shaping what is to come. We are a community.

We vow that, should a day come when, after serious and considerable deliberation, our spiritual journey leads us on different paths, we would be open and frank about our needs, and the others would be free to choose to break the bonds of oath in a frithful manner.

DISTELFINK:

Today we celebrate the growth of our kindred. Our actions move under the guiding hands of Fraa Holle, Queen of the Volk and Haerrin of the Urglaawe. As She oversees the death and rebirth of souls, we bid Her to bring a new life to Distelfink. As the new year begins, may our bonds grow stronger with the waxing sunlight!

ALL:

Hail Waahra!

Hail Holle!

ALL:

Hail Distelfink!

Free Thought: So, what's the story with Mistletoe?

This topic is just rising in my head as I look at all of the references to mistletoe during the holiday season. Why is mistletoe important?

Beyond the Norse stories of mistletoe being the plant that killed Balder, there are remnants of a mythology that indicates our distant ancestors viewed this plant with esteem. Called Mischdel or Mischdelzweig in Deutsch, mistletoe is viewed as having numerous medicinal properties. Folks may know of mistletoe grown on oak trees, but it also grows on many other trees, including willow, fir, birch, pear, lime and galangale. Lime and galangale are native to areas outside of the Germanic homelands, so their knowledge and uses may be later imports.

There is also a remnant of a myth that mistletoe belongs to the goddess of love. Where this comes from, I am not sure, but the Anglo-Saxons seem to have this myth rooted in Freya.

Mistletoe is a parasite that depends on its host plant in order to reproduce. It is said to have a very old spirit... Very, very old. In fact, it is one of very few organisms (another being lichens) that is said to be a survivor of a cosmic cycle prior to our own. Unable to interface with the mineral kingdom that evolved during this cycle, it must attach itself to those that can interface with the creations of this cycle. Mistletoe's spirit has experiences and understandings that we are unable to grasp, and here we begin to see a potential connection to Freid (Frigg).

Medicinally speaking, mistletoe is used to lower blood pressure and heart rate, to relieve anxiety and panic attacks, and to improve concentration. The potential toxicity of the berries, though, makes many people apprehensive about using the plant. From the spiritual angle, mistletoe, particularly from hazelnut (*Corylus* species in the Birch family, which is neither the *Hamamelis virginiana* known as American Witch Hazel nor the *Ulmus glabra*, which is Witch Hazel) and oak, is said to remove curses and the origins of fits, hysterics, etc. Underlying these uses is a sense of "righting the wrongs" or correcting ailments imposed from the outside.

Oak and Hazel

Oak has a pretty well-known connection to Dunner, and the same connection shows up in Continental German and Scandinavian lore. Hazel, though, is less known. We see a connection between hazel and the Butzemann (also connected to Freid at creation) in the Legend of Delbel the Butzemann. Hazel rods are used to make wishes, particularly regarding love, and to punish injustice. Folk songs sing to "Dame Hazel," (Fraa Hassel, Frau Hasel), and much of what surrounds the themes associated with hazel includes prudence, corrective action, and love.

Interestingly, there is a Verbot in Braucherei against the blending of the mistletoe from any two trees, particularly oak and hazel. In fact, the Verbot is likely derived from a Verbot against the blending of oak and hazel in any form, including acorns and hazelnuts. There is a superstition that the spirits of the two trees dislike and disagree with one another.

Other tales regarding hazel emerge from Deitsch, German, and Slavic cultures that seem to have some common themes running with our own. There is a belief that beneath hazel trees where mistletoe grows, there lies a snake with a gem on its head or a treasure nearby. This description of the snake brings the Schlangkeenich to mind, though it is a tangential point.

I am left to wonder whether there has been a prior association of hazelnut trees with a Germanic goddess. Because the hazelnut tree is usually classified in the Birch family, I begin to look particularly toward Berchta and Freid. Freid is of particular interest because of the relationship between mistletoe and hazel. One potential dot to connect is that Berchthold's Day (traditionally January 2 in Switzerland) includes nuts in the celebration. This is still under research.

This is, of course conjecture at this point. However, the next major observance is Entschtanning, which is closely tied to the Hearth Goddess (Freid). Perhaps we, as a community, can explore this more deeply.

A true Yule carol.

Deck the Halls

Deck the halls with boughs of holly,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.
Tis the season to be jolly,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.

Don we now our gay apparel,
Fa la la, la la la, la la la.
Troll the ancient Yule tide carol,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.

See the blazing Yule before us,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.
Strike the harp and join the chorus.
Fa la la la la, la la la la.

Follow me in merry measure,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.
While I tell of Yule tide treasure,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.

Fast away the old year passes,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.
Hail the new, ye lads and lasses,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.

Sing we joyous, all together,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.
Heedless of the wind and weather,
Fa la la la la, la la la la.